



STUDY GUIDE • IEUMUN 2026

DISEC

Disarmament and International Security Committee

Child Soldiers and Disarmament,
Demobilization, and Reintegration (DDR)

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01

Welcome Letter from the Chairs

A LETTER FROM

The DISEC Chairs

Dear Delegates,

It is our pleasure to welcome you to IEUMUN 2026 and, in particular, to the Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC). Before we proceed, we would like to briefly introduce ourselves and remind you that you can always contact us in order to clarify any doubts that you might have about the conference.

Arturs Juzenko

I am originally from Latvia and am currently pursuing a degree in Finance and Marketing at Hult International Business School in London. I came across MUN during my first year of university and have been hooked ever since, participating in and chairing conferences across Europe and beyond. At the moment, I lead our team's bid to host WorldMUN in Riga 2027, and earlier this year I had the privilege of helping our delegation take Best Large Delegation at Harvard WorldMUN. Before MUN took over my life, I competed in judo as a part of our national team, so I know a thing or two about staying composed under pressure. MUN has been one of the most meaningful parts of my university experience, and I really hope you come out of this conference with great memories and a deeper understanding of the issues we will be debating. You are always welcome to reach out if you need any guidance while you prepare. I am really looking forward to meeting you all in person. You can contact me at: arturs.juzenko@gmail.com

Nathan Mahagamage

I am from the tropical island nation of Sri Lanka and am currently doing my third year in Law at IE. I joined MUN through the IE Debate Club during my first year with the goal of competing in many conferences not only in Spain, but around the world. Since I started my journey 2 years ago, I have had the privilege of taking part in many conferences and meeting many interesting delegates. My most rewarding experience was winning an Honourable Mention in the Harvard National Model United Nations 2026 and being part of the IE delegation, where we won Outstanding Large Delegation, alongside Raquel as a team! Overall, the most fruitful part of my experience in MUN was the great talent and friendships I saw and made along the way. I am confident you will also feel the same way through your MUN journey and coming out of IE MUN. I am so looking forward to meeting you and wish you the best of luck for your preparation. Please feel free to reach out with any doubts or questions you may have at: mmarioperera.ieu2023@student.ie.edu

Raquel Vega

I am Spanish and am currently completing my fourth year of the dual degree in Law and International Relations at IE. I began my MUN journey after joining the IE Debate Club during my first year of university and have been participating in conferences all around the world ever since. Aside from chairing, I am also involved in the IE Debate Club as one of the Head Delegates for the team attending Harvard University's annual MUN Conference alongside Nathan. I am really looking forward to getting to know you all in person and wish you the best of luck as you prepare for the conference. For now, you are more than welcome to share any doubts that you might have by contacting me at: rvega.ieu2023@student.ie.edu

Now that we have introduced ourselves, let us remind you that, as Chairs, we will particularly value your capacity to produce original speeches and will place great importance on your ability to lead, take initiative, and work effectively with other members of the committee. We are really excited for the conference and wish you the best of luck in your preparation!

Sincerely,

The DISEC Chairs

02

List of Abbreviations

OPAC	Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child
CRC	Convention on the Rights of the Child
UNSC	United Nations Security Council
MRM	Monitoring and Reporting Mechanisms
PSS	Psychosocial Support

03

About the Committee

Mandate

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC) is the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, and its authority flows directly from the UN Charter rather than from any standing resolution. Under Article 11(1) of Chapter IV, the General Assembly may consider the general principles of cooperation in maintaining international peace and security, including the principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments, and may make recommendations on those principles to members states, to the Security Council or both.¹ DISEC is the body through which the Assembly exercises that function.

This produces a deliberately broad remit. The Committee considers every disarmament and international security question that fall within the scope of the charter or relates to the powers of other UN organs alongside the general principles of cooperation in maintaining peace and the regulation of armaments.² In practice the agenda is organized into seven thematic clusters: nuclear weapons, other weapons of mass destruction, outer space (disarmament aspects), conventional weapons, other disarmament measures and international security, regional disarmament and security, and the disarmament machinery.³ Each annual session runs in three stages: a general debate, thematic discussions across those clusters, and action on draft resolutions.⁴

The defining limit on this mandate is that DISEC cannot compel anyone. Its resolutions are recommendations rather than a binding law. They carry weight because they are debated and adopted by all UN member states and can establish customs, standards,

¹ United Nations. (1945). *Charter of the United Nations, Chapter IV: The General Assembly (Articles 9–22)*. <https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/chapter-4>

² United Nations General Assembly. (n.d.). *Disarmament and International Security (First Committee)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/index.shtml>

³ United Nations. (2024, October 3). *First Committee, in brief organizational meeting, sets out guidelines for completing its work within allotted time frame (GA/DIS/3734)*. <https://press.un.org/en/2024/gadis3734.doc.htm>

⁴ United Nations General Assembly. (n.d.). *Disarmament and International Security (First Committee)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/index.shtml>

and normative expectations over time, but they hold no enforcement power of their own.⁵ The Charter draws the boundary more sharply still: under Article 12, while the Security Council is exercising its function over a dispute or situation, the GA may not make a recommendation on that matter unless the Council requests it.⁶ To conclude, DISEC sets norms and frameworks, it does not authorize force, impose sanctions, or adjudicate a live crisis the Council has seized.

DISEC also does not operate in isolation. It works in close coordination with the United Nations Disarmament Commission and the Geneva based Conference on Disarmament, and it receives substantive and organizational support from the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA).⁷ UNODA was first established in 1982 on the recommendation of the Assembly's second special session on disarmament, restructured in 1998, and given its current name in 2007. It supports the norm-setting work of the First Committee, the Disarmament Commission, and the Conference on Disarmament and maintains instruments such as the UN Register of Conventional Arms.⁸ One mark of the Committee's standing is procedural: under Rule 58(a) of the Assembly's rules of procedure, the First Committee is the only Main Committee entitled to verbatim records of its meetings, the same word-for-word coverage given to the Assembly plenary and the Security Council.⁹

For this year's topic, the mandate maps cleanly onto the disarmament half of the agenda. UNODA's remit explicitly covers practical, post-conflict disarmament measures such as disarming and demobilising former combatants, which places the disarmament and reintegration of fighters, including children, within the First Committee's competence.¹⁰ The flow of small arms and light weapons that arm child soldiers, and the frameworks governing their collection and destruction during DDR, are core conventional arms business for DISEC. What sits outside the committee's reach is the humanitarian and child-protection machinery handled elsewhere in the UN system. While DISEC can build the disarmament architecture and the norms around reintegration, it cannot run prosecutions or direct field protection operations. Keeping resolutions on the disarmament and security side of that line is what keeps them in order.

5 Reaching Critical Will. (n.d.). *First Committee of the UN General Assembly*. Women's International League for Peace and Freedom. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.reachingcriticalwill.org/disarmament-fora/unga>

6 United Nations. (1945). *Charter of the United Nations, Chapter IV: The General Assembly (Articles 9–22)*. <https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/chapter-4>

7 United Nations General Assembly. (n.d.). *Disarmament and International Security (First Committee)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/index.shtml>

8 United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. (n.d.). *About us*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://disarmament.unoda.org/en/who-we-are/about-unoda>

9 United Nations General Assembly. (n.d.). *Rules of procedure of the General Assembly, IX. Records (Rules 58–59)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/en/ga/about/ropga/recds.shtml>; United Nations Department for General Assembly and Conference Management. (n.d.). *Verbatim reporting*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/dgacm/en/content/verbatim-reporting>

10 Nuclear Threat Initiative. (2025, September 18). *United Nations Office of Disarmament Affairs (UNODA)*. <https://www.nti.org/education-center/treaties-and-regimes/un-office-of-disarmament-affairs/>

History

DISEC's history follows one clear trajectory. It began by trying to contain the deadliest weapons ever built, and over time broadened to confront the everyday weapons and practices that drive most actual conflict.

The committee is as old as the UN itself. When the organisation was founded in 1945, the General Assembly was tasked with considering the principles of disarmament and the regulation of armaments, and the First Committee became the standing forum for that work.¹¹ For its first decades, that meant the Cold War and the nuclear arms race. The debate of this era produced the foundation of the nonproliferation regime, the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, opened for signature in 1968 and in force since 1970 (cite).

The system that still governs UN disarmament was set in 1978 at the General Assembly's first special session devoted entirely to disarmament, whose Final Document defined the priorities that continue to guide this work.¹² That session built the wider machinery DISEC operates within, including the Disarmament Commission and the Geneva-based Conference on Disarmament.

The end of the Cold War changed the agenda. With the superpower standoff over, the committee expanded beyond weapons of mass destruction to the threats that shape conflict on the ground: the illicit trade in small arms and light weapons, the disarmament and demobilization of former combatants and, more recently, the military use of emerging technologies.¹³ The clearest result of this shift is the Arms Trade Treaty adopted by the General Assembly in 2013 and in force since 2014, the first binding global rules on the trade in conventional weapons from small arms to warships.¹⁴¹⁵ Norm building continued in 2017 with the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons in force since 2021.¹⁶

¹¹ United Nations General Assembly. (n.d.). *Disarmament and International Security (First Committee)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/index.shtml>; United Nations. (1945). *Charter of the United Nations, Chapter IV: The General Assembly (Articles 9–22)*. <https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/chapter-4>

¹² United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. (n.d.). *Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT)*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://disarmament.unoda.org/en/our-work/weapons-mass-destruction/nuclear-weapons/treaty-non-proliferation-nuclear-weapons>

¹³ United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. (n.d.). *About us*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://disarmament.unoda.org/en/who-we-are/about-unoda>

¹⁴ Nuclear Threat Initiative. (2025, September 18). *United Nations Office of Disarmament Affairs (UNODA)*. <https://www.nti.org/education-center/treaties-and-regimes/un-office-of-disarmament-affairs/>

¹⁵ United Nations Regional Centre for Peace and Disarmament in Asia and the Pacific. (n.d.). *Arms Trade Treaty*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://www.unrcpd.org/conventional-weapons/arms-trade-treaty>

¹⁶ United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. (n.d.). *Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons*. Retrieved June 14, 2026, from <https://disarmament.unoda.org/en/our-work/weapons-mass-destruction/nuclear-weapons/treaty-prohibition-nuclear-weapons>

04

About the Topic

Key Terms

The following terms will be mentioned various times throughout the study guide and must be known by delegates in order to better understand and address the problem of child soldier use and recruitment.

Child Soldiers

Any person under 18 years of age who is recruited, used, or associated with government armed forces or non-state armed forces groups in any capacity. Note that this definition does not only refer to children who have been directly engaged in fighting, but also includes those who have been used to serve as messengers, cooks, porters, spies, or sexual slaves¹⁷.

Disarmament

The laying aside of arms or the reduction of military capacity to a set minimum¹⁸.

Demobilization

The formal act and controlled discharge of active combatants from armed forces or other groups¹⁹.

¹⁷ United Nations Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. *Child Recruitment and Use*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/six-grave-violations/child-soldiers>

¹⁸ *Disarmament*. Merriam-Webster. <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/disarmament>

¹⁹ Social Development Department. *Disarmament, Demobilization and Reintegration*. No. 119. 2009. https://au.int/sites/default/files/documents/39242-doc-192_social_development_notes_conflict_crime_and_violence.pdf

Reintegration

The process through which minors formerly related to armed groups or conflicts are brought back to society by reunifying them with their families and providing them with physical and psychological assistance, economic support, education, or vocational training.

Paris Principles (2007)

A set of international guidelines which seek to protect children in war contexts, prevent the re-recruitment of child soldiers, and help them reintegrate back into society.

Optional Protocol on Children in Armed Conflict (OPAC)

Adopted in the year 2000, this protocol builds upon the statements made in the famous Convention on the Rights of the Child by further protecting children from being recruited by armed groups to participate in hostile environments and by setting the minimum age for conscription at 18.

Grave Violations framework

In the year 2005, the UNSC created a Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism (MRM) which sought to monitor, document and report on violations against children's rights taking place all around the world. It recognised six types of grave violations of children's rights: the killing and maiming of children; the recruitment or use of children as soldiers; the commission of sexual violence against children; the execution of child abductions; the performance of attacks against schools or hospitals; and the denial of humanitarian access for children²⁰.

Psychosocial Support (PSS)

This relates to the rehabilitation efforts performed in an attempt to address both the psychological and social impacts of war on former child soldiers. The most common psychological wounds that arise in these contexts are trauma or PTSD, while the main

²⁰ United Nations Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. *The Six Grave Violations*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/six-grave-violations>

social challenges that children formerly associated with armed conflict experience usually range from stigma, to loss of educational and professional opportunities.

Introduction to the Topic

The illicit recruitment and use of children in armed conflict illustrate a serious, if not one of the gravest violations of international humanitarian law.²¹ Through history and in present reality, tens of thousands of children – many of whom are under the age of 15 – are faced with being forcibly conscripted, abducted or coerced into service by both state militaries and non-state armed groups. They are often used as fighters, spies, or human shields, and are stripped of their childhood and dignity at a very young age. The persistence of the recruitment of child soldiers, despite decades of international condemnation, reflects the structural failures for accountability and post-conflict support.

As a potential solution to address the aftermath of child recruitment, the Disarmament, Demobilization, and Reintegration (DDR) emerged.²² The DDR attempts to break the cycle of conflict by facilitating the transition of former combatants, particularly children, back into civilian society. Such a framework addresses concerns that are not usually considered in military solutions that focus on immediate security. Each phase of the DDR attempts to deal with distinct challengers: disarmament being designed to include children who have never bore arms; demobilization requiring careful identification and interim care; and reintegration, which demands sustained long-term investment in children, families, communities and individuals that the system has failed to protect.

International frameworks already in place governing child soldiers are abundant but remain fragmented in terms of their enforcement. The Convention on the Rights of Child (1989),²³ the Optional Protocol on Children in Armed Conflict (2000)²⁴, the Rome Statute (1998)²⁵, and the Paris Principles (2007)²⁶ all collectively prohibit the recruitment

²¹ History Extra. *Innocence under Fire: How Children were Used in Warfare of the Past*. 2021.<https://www.historyextra.com/period/first-world-war/how-children-used-warfare-fighting-child-soldiers/>

²² United Nations. *Integrated Disarmament, Demobilization and Reintegration Standards (IDDRS)*. 2014.<https://www.unddr.org/iddrs/>

²³ United Nations General Assembly. *Convention on the Rights of the Child*. UN Doc. A/RES/44/25. November 20, 1989

²⁴ United Nations General Assembly. *Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the Involvement of Children in Armed Conflict*. UN Doc. A/RES/54/263. May 25, 2000

²⁵ United Nations Diplomatic Conference of Plenipotentiaries. *Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court*. UN Doc. A/CONF.183/9. July 17, 1998

²⁶ UNICEF. *The Paris Principles: Principles and Guidelines on Children Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups*. February 2007.<https://www.unicef.org/emerg/files/ParisPrinciples310107English.pdf>

and the use of children, state the obligations of each state and non-state actors, and establish compliance procedures for DDR programming. The United Nations Security Council has also passed many resolutions on children and armed conflict. For instance, Resolution 2427²⁷, which will be explained later throughout the study guide, stands as the most cohesive statement on child soldiers to date. Nevertheless, the ratification and enforcement of such frameworks remain limited in reality, particularly in regions where armed groups operate outside of state authority.

The Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism (MRM), established under Security Council Resolution 1612 (2005), tracks grave violations against children in armed conflict, and its annual Secretary-General reports name all the parties (state and non-state) response.²⁸ Parties that appear on this “list of shame” are expected to enter into formal Action plans with the UN, committing to end such grave violations. The MRM to date, has remained one of the most operationally fundamental accountability tools available to the international community although the delisting process has shown mixed results.

The challenge of child soldiers remains particularly relevant in current conflicts. In the Democratic Republic of Congo, the Congo, Somalia, South Sudan, the Central African Republic, Myanmar, and Mali, children continue to be recruited and used by both government forces and non-state armed groups.²⁹ Multi-actors – where dozens of armed factions may operate simultaneously within a single country – complicates the DDR implementation significantly. The DDR addresses post-conflict transitions, therefore rendering the framework ill-suited to ongoing fighting environments. The committee must explore therefore, how DDR frameworks can be adapted towards dynamic conflict settings that continue without a formal peace agreement.

DiSEC is well-suited to address this issue as DDR programs sit at the heart of disarmament, security, and humanitarian policy (the key mandate of what this committee hopes to achieve)³⁰. Delegates must take into consideration approaches to strengthen accountability for parties that recruit children, close the gap between enforcement in existing legal frameworks, ensure sustainable and adequate funding mechanisms for transition programs, and develop key frameworks that serve all categories of children affected by armed conflict. The question facing this committee is not simply how to free children

²⁷ United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 2427 (2018)*. UN Doc. S/RES/2427. July 9, 2018

²⁸ United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 1612 (2005)*. UN Doc. S/RES/1612. July 26, 2005.

²⁹ United Nations Secretary-General. *Children and Armed Conflict: Report of the Secretary-General*. UN Doc. A/78/842-S/2024/384. May 2024. https://www.un.org/ga/search/view_doc.asp?symbol=S/2024/384

³⁰ United Nations General Assembly. *Disarmament and International Security Committee (First Committee): Mandate and Functions*. <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/>

from armed groups, but rather, how to guarantee them a safe and secure future, and how the international community can build and deliver on that promise.

History of the Topic

Origins

The use of children in armed conflicts is not as recent as it may seem. Children have been involved in war contexts since ancient and medieval times. A good example is that of Spartan boys who were taken away from their families at the age of seven to join a military training program referred to as the “agoge” which effectively prepared them to become soldiers once they were older³¹. This practice persisted throughout the Modern Era since there is historical evidence that Napoleon resorted to the recruitment of children throughout the final stages of the Napoleonic Wars in 1814 when faced with invasion by Allied forces³². Later on, about 250,000 boys aged below 18 enlisted themselves in the army to fight for Britain throughout the First World War. Most of them were driven by nationalist narratives or by a desire to escape poverty at home³³. Something similar happened in World War Two, where Nazi Germany used slightly untrained and underaged members of the “Hitler Youth” group to fight the Allies, particularly during the battle of Berlin of 1945³⁴.

Modern Child Soldier Crisis

However, what is known as the “Modern Child Soldier Crisis” only began throughout the 20th Century. It is during this period that various civil wars mainly taking place mainly in Africa but also in other regions made the practice of child soldier use and recruitment more visible. Throughout Sierra Leone’s Civil War taking place between 1991 and 2002, approximately 50% of the children recruited by rebel forces were abducted at the age of 15 or below³⁵. In Liberia, children have played a central role in government and rebel armies

³¹ History Extra. *Innocence under Fire: How Children were Used in Warfare of the Past*. 2021. <https://www.historyextra.com/period/first-world-war/how-children-used-warfare-fighting-child-soldiers/>

³² Graeber Daniel. *Child Soldiers: A Timeless Struggle*. Foreign Policy Association. <https://fpa.org/child-soldiers-a-timeless-struggle/>

³³ *The Teenage Soldiers of World War One*. BBC News. 2014. <https://www.bbc.com/news/magazine-29934965>

³⁴ *Hitler Youth: How the Third Reich Used Children's Organisations to Wage War*. History Extra. 2020. <https://www.historyextra.com/period/second-world-war/hitler-youth-children-history-soldiers-fight-jojo-rabbit-film-ww2/>

³⁵ Betancourt Theresa S. et al. *Sierra Leone's Child Soldiers: War Exposures and Mental Health Problems*. Gender National Library of Medicine. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3124662/>

since the nation's civil war dating back to the 1990s³⁶. Similarly, the International Labour Office estimates that, in the Democratic Republic of Congo, the Alliance of Democratic Forces for the Liberation of the Congo (AFDL) recruited about 10,000 children aged between 7 and 16 between the years 1996 and 1997³⁷. In Latin America, particularly in Mexico, children have also historically been used by drug cartels who promise them status and a sense of belonging in exchange for their participation in hostile environments³⁸.

Recent Events

More recently, Human Rights Watch recalled how the UN had been able to verify 2,138 violations against minors in armed conflict taking place in Myanmar in 2024. Among these violations was the recruitment of children into the military³⁹. Likewise, it has been documented that over 620 children were recruited by armed criminal groups in Colombia in 2024⁴⁰. As it will be documented later throughout this study guide, these practices have remained in place in some of the most recent armed conflicts, such as the Russia-Ukraine or Israel-Palestine Conflicts.

Past Actions

The table below shows the various existing treaties and conventions which have sought to protect children from becoming involved in armed conflict:

Year	Treaty/Convention	Entity	Relevance
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³⁶ Pan Esther. *Liberia: Child Soldiers*. Council on Foreign Relations. 2005. <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounders/liberia-child-soldiers>

³⁷ International Labour Office. *Wounded Childhood: The Use of Children in Armed Conflict in Central Africa*. 2003. https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/wcmsp5/groups/public/@ed_emp/@emp_ent/@ifp_crisis/documents/publication/wcms_116566.pdf

³⁸ Child Soldiers International. *Child Soldiers Global Report 2001 - Mexico*. 2001 <https://www.refworld.org/reference/annualreport/cscoal/2001/65235>

³⁹ Human Rights Watch. *Myanmar: Stop Recruitment, Use of Child Soldiers*. 2025. <https://www.hrw.org/news/2025/06/20/myanmar-stop-recruitment-use-of-child-soldiers>

⁴⁰ *Kids on the Front Lines: Stopping Child Recruitment in Colombia*. International Crisis Group. Colombia. 2026. <https://www.crisisgroup.org/brf/latin-america-caribbean/colombia/b55-kids-front-lines-stopping-child-recruitment-colombia>

1977	Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the Protection of Victims of International Armed Conflicts (Protocol I).	Diplomatic Conference on the Reaffirmation and Development of International Humanitarian Law Applicable in Armed Conflicts.	Article 77(2) of Protocol I sets forth that children below 15 years old shall not be recruited to partake in hostilities ⁴¹ .
1989	Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC).	Adopted by the UN General Assembly through Resolution 44/25.	Article 38 establishes that children should not be part of armed conflicts, and that those who have been involved in them should obtain assistance in order to recover and be able to fully reintegrate themselves back into society ⁴² .
1990	African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child.	African Union.	Article 22 calls upon member states to refrain from recruiting children to take part in armed conflicts ⁴³ .
1998	Rome Statute.	International Criminal Court.	Article 8(2)(e)(7) defines the conscription or use of children in armed conflicts as a war crime ⁴⁴ .
1999	Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention (No.182).	International Labour Organization.	Article 3(a) recognises “forced or compulsory recruitment of children for use in armed conflict” as one of the “worst forms of child labour” ⁴⁵ .
2000	Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child (OPAC) on the involvement of children in armed conflict.	Adopted by the UN General Assembly under Resolution A/RES/54/263.	States that signed this protocol promised not to send children aged below 18 to fight in armed conflicts, as well as to provide physical and psychological assistance to children who had been involved in hostilities ⁴⁶ .

In addition, the following table summarises some of the most relevant resolutions on the topic of child soldiers adopted by the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), which could be taken as a reference by this committee:

Year	Resolution	Relevance
1999	Resolution 1261	Denounced the recruitment of children in armed conflicts, acknowledging the harmful long-term consequences that this encompasses ⁴⁷ .
2001	Resolution 1379	Primarily asked the Secretary-General to identify the parties to armed conflict that recruited or used child soldiers ⁴⁸ .
2005	Resolution 1612	Condemned the use and recruitment of child soldiers and endorsed the Secretary-General's Monitoring and Reporting Mechanisms (MRM) action plan aimed at collecting information on armed groups and governments that committed abuses against children during armed conflicts ⁴⁹ .
2014	Resolution 2143	Acknowledged the importance of demobilization, rehabilitation and reintegration programs for children in armed conflicts ⁵⁰ .
2018	Resolution 2427	Emphasised that former child soldiers should be guaranteed access to schooling in order to avoid chances of them being recruited again in the future as a result of poverty, mentioned the importance of providing them with psychosocial support, and urged for the different needs of girls and boys to be taken into account for the preparation of tailored reintegration programs ⁵¹ .

⁴¹ Diplomatic Conference on the Reaffirmation and Development of International Humanitarian Law Applicable in Armed Conflicts. *Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the Protection of Victims of International Armed Conflicts (Protocol I)*. 1977. <https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-77?activeTab=>

⁴² UN General Assembly resolution 44/25. *Convention on the Rights of the Child*. 1989. <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-rights-child>

⁴³ African Union. *African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child*. Ethiopia. 1990. https://au.int/sites/default/files/treaties/36804-treaty-african_charter_on_rights_welfare_of_the_child.pdf

⁴⁴ International Criminal Court. *Rome Statute*. 1998. <https://www.icc-cpi.int/sites/default/files/2024-05/Rome-Statute-eng.pdf>

⁴⁵ International Labour Organization. *Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention (No.182)*. 1999. https://normlex.ilo.org/dyn/nrmlx_en/f?p=NORMLEXPUB:12100:0::NO::P12100_ILO_CODE:C182

⁴⁶ General Assembly resolution A/RES/54/263. *Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict*. 2000. <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/optional-protocol-convention-rights-child-involvement-children>

Now that a range of relevant treaties, conventions and UN resolutions have been outlined, it is also worth mentioning how efforts to combat the recruitment of children by parties to armed conflicts have also been made through the implementation of a variety of frameworks, guidelines and initiatives.

In 2014, the UN Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict worked with UNICEF to tackle the issue at hand by launching the “Children, Not Soldiers” campaign, which sought to bring about international consensus on the fact that children should not become involved in war. This initiative released and reintegrated thousands of child soldiers⁵². More generally, it is estimated that UNICEF has been able to deliver protection and reintegration assistance to approximately 12,500 former child soldiers⁵³. Similarly, the United Nations has partnered with the African Union to foster Disarmament, Demobilization and Reintegration (DDR) Programs focused on removing weapons from child soldiers, releasing them from working for armed groups, and reintegrating them back into society through education and psychological support⁵⁴.

In 2007, the UN also launched the Principles and Guidelines on Children Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups, informally referred to as the Paris Principles, which are a set of guidelines created to prevent child soldiers from being recruited, guarantee their release once recruited, and reintegrate them back into society after they have been released⁵⁵. The Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers of 2017, which are a set of political commitments aimed at eliminating the use of child soldiers during UN peacekeeping operations, are also relevant since they advocate that peacekeepers must be trained on how to protect

47 United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 1261*. 1999. <https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/atf/cf/%7B65BFCF9B-6D27-4E9C-8CD3-CF6E4FF96FF9%7D/CAC%20SRES%201261.pdf>

48 United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 1379*. 2001. file:///C:/Users/Usuario/Downloads/S_RES_1379(2001)-EN.pdf

49 United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 1612*. 2005. file:///C:/Users/Usuario/Downloads/S_RES_1612(2005)-EN%20(1).pdf

50 United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 2143*. 2014. file:///C:/Users/Usuario/Downloads/S_RES_2143(2014)-EN.pdf

51 United Nations Security Council. *Resolution 2427*. 2018. <https://unscr.com/en/resolutions/doc/2427/>

52 UN Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. *Child Recruitment and Use*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/six-grave-violations/child-soldiers>

53 Haupt Naomi. *Keeping the Spotlight on Africa's Child Soldiers*. Institute for Security Studies. 2025. <https://issafrica.org/iss-today/keeping-the-spotlight-on-africa-s-child-soldiers> that

54 United Nations. *Disarmament, Demobilization, Reintegration (DDR) & Weapons and Ammunitions Management (WAM) with human rights approach*. United Nations Office to the African Union. <https://unoau.unmissions.org/en/disarmament-demobilization-reintegration-ddr-weapons-and-ammunitions-management-wam-with>

55 United Nations. *Principles and Guidelines on Children Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups*. 2007. <https://www.unicef.org/mali/media/1561/file/parisprinciples.pdf>

minors and that violations against children's rights during peacekeeping operations must be adequately monitored and reported⁵⁶.

Likewise, while future sections in this study guide will provide a more detailed overview of the different regional efforts aimed at addressing the problem of child soldiers, it is worth noting how the European Union's adoption of the Guidelines on Children and Armed Conflict in 2003 stands out as a key initiative which supports the prevention of child soldier use and recruitment through DDR programs⁵⁷. Likewise, the Kathmandu Declaration on the Use of Children as Soldiers is also a relevant statement which called for the implementation of measures such as the denial of arms to groups using child soldiers. This was signed by 30 different countries at the Asia-Pacific Conference held in Nepal in the year 2000⁵⁸.

Finally, the Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers used to stand out as an active global coalition composed of human rights and humanitarian organizations that sought to monitor, denounce, and prevent the use of children in war contexts. Its main activities included the drafting of reports that document the recruitment of child soldiers across the world and the development of campaigns seeking to raise awareness about the problem as well as to advocate for the implementation of stronger and more effective international laws aimed at deterring armed groups and governments from using child soldiers⁵⁹.

⁵⁶ Government of Canada. *The Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers*. 2017. <https://www.canada.ca/en/department-national-defence/corporate/reports-publications/vancouver-principles/introduction.html>

⁵⁷ European Union. *EU Guidelines on Children and Armed Conflict*. 2003. <https://www.eeas.europa.eu/sites/default/files/documents/2024/EEAS-EU-Guidelines-CAAC.pdf>

⁵⁸ Human Rights Watch. *Kathmandu Declaration on the Use of Children as Soldiers*. <https://www.hrw.org/news/2000/05/18/kathmandu-declaration-use-children-soldiers>

⁵⁹ Amnesty International. *Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers*. 2004. <https://www.amnesty.org/es/wp-content/uploads/2021/08/act760022004en.pdf>

05

Current Situation

Problem Statement

According to UNICEF, between the years 2005 and 2022, over 105,000 children have been recruited to participate in armed conflicts. While it is widely known that these children are oftentimes used as fighters, less people are aware of the fact that they are occasionally also used as cooks, spies, sex slaves, bomb makers, guards, porters, messengers, and suicide bombers⁶⁰. At the moment, this practice is particularly prevalent across certain parts of Asia, Africa, and South America⁶¹. More importantly, Human Rights Watch affirms that around 30% of armed groups integrated by children contain girls, generally subject to sexual abuse and sometimes even taken as mistresses of rebel army leaders in countries like Uganda, Angola or Sierra Leone⁶². There have also been cases of child soldier recruitment in the Russia-Ukraine and Israel-Palestine Conflicts. For example, according to The Child Labour Coalition, in certain parts of Siberia, minors are put in charge of sewing items and preparing care packages for Russian troops fighting in Ukraine and city administrators in Krasnoyarsk have sent representatives to some schools to recruit children⁶³. Similarly, a very recent Report of the Secretary-General on Children and Armed Conflict drafted this year has verified that Palestinian children were used by

⁶⁰ UNICEF. *Children Recruited by Armed Forces or Armed Groups*. 2021. <https://www.unicef.org/protection/children-recruited-by-armed-forces>

⁶¹ EBSCO Information Services. *Child Soldiers*. Research Starters: Military History and Science. <https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/military-history-and-science/child-soldiers#full-article>

⁶² Human Rights Watch. *Stop the Use of Child Soldiers - Statements and Resolutions*. 2001. <https://www.hrw.org/news/2001/06/01/stop-use-child-soldiers-statements-and-resolutions>

⁶³ Greenberger Sydney. *New Report on Children and Armed Conflict — The Use of Child Soldiers*. The Child Soldier Coalition. 2024. <https://stopchildlabor.org/new-report-on-children-and-armed-conflict-the-use-of-child-soldiers/>

Israeli armed and security forces as human shields during operations in the West Bank as well as in the Gaza Strip⁶⁴.

A lot of children are violently taken away from their homes to serve as soldiers or to carry out other roles in armed conflicts⁶⁵. However, many of them also decide to join armed groups because they are indoctrinated through nationalist arguments or because they see this as an opportunity to escape poverty. In fact, a report developed by War Child UK titled “Tug of War: Children in Armed Groups in DRC” exposes how a large part of children in the Democratic Republic of Congo voluntarily enlist in the military. According to this report, what makes them willing to become involved in conflict is the absence of a stable and caring family environment⁶⁶. This suggests that there is a pressing need to tackle poverty and instability across the regions where the problem of child soldiers is still present.

In addition, it is also worth considering how, when taking part in armed conflicts, children are often forced to witness very violent killings, rapes, beheadings, limb amputations, and burnings of people alive. Along these lines, many children who are involved in armed conflicts from a young age are also indoctrinated by the armed groups that recruit them. All of this leaves them with lasting physical and mental health problems which might affect their capacity to reintegrate themselves back into society once they are released⁶⁷. Furthermore, child soldiers are also deprived of a quality education and denied the possibility of living a normal childhood. This limits their future professional opportunities and perpetuates cycles of poverty in post-conflict regions. It is therefore necessary to further expand and improve existing rehabilitation and reintegration schemes, tailoring them to the circumstances of each former child soldier, focusing, in particular, on the activities that they had to perform while recruited by armed groups during periods of war.

Another issue which has generally been overlooked is the fact that girls often find it harder to escape and usually encounter greater social stigma once they are able to return

⁶⁴ United Nations General Assembly. *Children and armed conflict - Report of the Secretary-General (A/80/723-S/2026/357)*. 2026. <https://reliefweb.int/report/world/children-and-armed-conflict-report-secretary-general-a80-723-s2026357>

⁶⁵ International Committee of the Red Cross. *Children Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups*. Geneva, Switzerland. 2013. <https://www.icrc.org/sites/default/files/external/doc/en/assets/files/publications/icrc-002-0824.pdf>

⁶⁶ *Why do Children Become Child Soldiers?* War Child. 2018. <https://www.warchild.org.uk/news/why-do-children-become-child-soldiers>

⁶⁷ Kaplan Eben. *Child Soldiers around the World*. Council on Foreign Relations. 2005. <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/child-soldiers-around-world>

home⁶⁸. Researcher Milfrid Tonheim exposes how most of the child soldiers that are freed are boys. She explains how this is because international organizations such as UNICEF need to cooperate with the commanders of armed groups in order to free children who have been forcibly recruited. They usually receive lists with the names of the underaged children which they need to save but the girl's names are most of the time not included since the commanders of the armed groups that take them generally see them as their mistresses. On top of this, many of the girls who manage to escape are then marginalised by their communities. Some families find it hard to accept that their daughters who were once kidnapped and raped by commanders of rebel armed forces are no longer virgins and might not be able to get married. If the daughters arrive pregnant things get even worse, since they and their newborns will be considered financial burdens⁶⁹.

Finally, although a number of treaties, conventions, and resolutions have been put in place in order to tackle the use and recruitment of child soldiers in conflict zones, these are rarely ratified by all countries and are oftentimes difficult to enforce. Armed groups are aware that children can be very easily lured into becoming involved in the military and they effectively take advantage of this. Hence, it is also important to strengthen the enforcement mechanisms that are already in place, while making sure that both governments and non-state groups who use and recruit child soldiers are adequately sanctioned and held accountable for their actions.

Possible Solutions

This section examines how already existing frameworks and initiatives could be improved in order to better tackle the problem of child soldier use and recruitment across the globe. It also puts forward some possible solutions which have not yet been implemented and which we would like all delegates to expand further in their draft resolutions.

Solutions to the child soldier problem cannot sit in one phase of the conflict cycle. They have to run from prevention, through release and reintegration, to accountability, and they have to work while fighting is still active, not only after a peace agreement. Delegates should keep proposals within DISEC's disarmament and security mandate rather than straying into field protection or prosecution, which sit with other organs.

⁶⁸ Plan International. *Hidden in plain sight: girls associated with armed groups*. Plan International. 2026. <https://plan-international.org/blog/2026/02/11/hidden-in-plain-sight-girls-associated-with-armed-groups/>

⁶⁹ Grønhaug Kristene. *The Number of Child Soldiers in the World is Increasing – Almost Half of Them are Girls*. Flykninghjelpen Norwegian Refugee Council. <https://www.nrc.no/shorthand/stories/child-soldiers/index.html>

Prevention and root causes

Recruitment is driven by poverty and the absence of alternatives as much as by force. War Child UK's research in the Kivus found that many children enlist "voluntarily" because they lack a stable family environment and see no economic future⁷⁰. Prevention therefore means restoring access to education, one of the strongest protective factors⁷¹, expanding adolescent livelihoods, and strengthening birth and civil registration so a child's age can actually be verified at recruitment, now a standard commitment in UN action plans⁷². The Safe Schools Declaration and Security Council Resolution 2601 (2021) reduce exposure by limiting the military use of schools⁷³.

Adapting DDR

The IDDRS already treats child release as a human rights obligation that is not contingent on any political negotiation and should be pursued during conflict⁷⁴, and the 2019 UN Approach to DDR extends guidance to settings with no peace agreement⁷⁵. Two fixes matter most: decouple DDR eligibility from surrendering a weapon, since that criterion excludes girls and support roles⁷⁶, and fund community-based reintegration over several years rather than in short humanitarian cycles. Funding fell by roughly a third between 2012 and 2016 as need rose⁷⁷, so the Global Coalition for Reintegration argues for treating reintegration as development, not short-term relief.

⁷⁰ War Child UK. (2018). *Why do children become child soldiers?*<https://www.warchild.org.uk/news/why-do-children-become-child-soldiers>

⁷¹ Education Above All. (n.d.). *Education of former child soldiers*.<https://www.educationaboveall.org/sites/default/files/research/attachments/02.%20EducationChildSoldiersEN.pdf>

⁷² Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. (n.d.). *Action plans*.<https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/tools-for-action/action-plans/>

⁷³ Security Council Report. (2026, June). *Children and armed conflict: June 2026 monthly forecast*.<https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/monthly-forecast/2026-06/children-and-armed-conflict-12.php>

⁷⁴ United Nations Inter-Agency Working Group on DDR. (2023). *IDDRS 5.20: Children and DDR*.<https://www.unddr.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/IDDRS-5.20-Children-and-DDR.pdf>

⁷⁵ United Nations. (2019). *The IDDRS and the UN approach to DDR*.<https://www.unddr.org/the-iddrs/>

⁷⁶ Global Coalition for Reintegration of Child Soldiers. (2020). *Reframing child reintegration: From humanitarian action to development*.<https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/09/GCR-Reframing-Child-Reintegration-92020.pdf>

⁷⁷ Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. (n.d.). *Global Coalition for Reintegration of Child Soldiers*.<https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/global-coalition-for-reintegration-of-child-soldiers>

Gender

Girls are undercounted because releases run through commander-supplied lists that leave them off, so those freed are disproportionately boys⁷⁸, and returnees face the worst stigma, girls' mothers most of all. Resolution 2427 (2018) already calls for tailored programmes⁷⁹, making that real means counting girls in negotiated releases, funding gender specific psychosocial and medical care, and investing in community sensitisation.

Accountability

The gap is enforcement, not law. Strengthen the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism and the action plan system, of which 38 have been signed, and 12 fully complied with, and tie delisting to verified reintegration, rather than a declared halt⁸⁰. Despite this architecture, the Secretary-General verified 41,370 grave violations in 2024, up 25%⁸¹. The ICC has real precedent under Article 8 of the Rome Statute in Lubanga, Ntaganda and Ongwen.⁸² Since leaders evade any single court, states should use universal jurisdiction and national prosecutions, while distinguishing child victims from adult perpetrators, the dilemma the Ongwen case exposed. National leverage like the US Child Soldiers Prevention Act works only when applied consistently rather than waived for strategic partners, as noted in Key Stakeholders.

⁷⁸ Grønhaug, K. (n.d.). *The number of child soldiers in the world is increasing – almost half of them are girls*. Norwegian Refugee Council. <https://www.nrc.no/shorthand/stories/child-soldiers/index.html>

⁷⁹ United Nations Security Council. (2018). *Resolution 2427*. <https://unscr.com/en/resolutions/doc/2427/>

⁸⁰ Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. (n.d.). *Action plans*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/tools-for-action/action-plans/>

⁸¹ United Nations Secretary-General. (2025). *Children and armed conflict: Report of the Secretary-General (covering 2024)*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/Secretary-General-Annual-Report-on-Children-and-Armed-Conflict-Covering-2024.pdf>

⁸² International Criminal Court. *The Prosecutor v. Thomas Lubanga Dyilo* (14 years, 2012); *Ntaganda* (30 years, 2019); *Ongwen* (25 years, 2021). <https://www.icc-cpi.int/drc/lubanga>

06

Key Stakeholders & Blocs

The following section summarises the different positions and initiatives taken across regions on the issue of child soldier use and recruitment, while providing an overview of some of the actions that have already been taken by international organizations, NGOs, and civil society.

Western Bloc

Western states such as the United States, the United Kingdom, France, and Germany have tackled the issue primarily through legislative and financial leverage rather than through direct intervention. For instance, the United States enacted the Child Soldiers Prevention Act (CSPA) in 2008, requiring the publication of an annual list of governments that recruit child soldiers and prohibits certain types of U.S. Security assistance to such countries that engage in this practice⁸³. The law was later strengthened by the Child Soldier Prevention Act of 2018.⁸⁴ In reality, however, the leverage has been political and inconsistently applied at best. The Biden Administration, for instance, had identified 17 governments complicit in child soldier use or recruitment, restricting arms sales and military assistance to nine of them while still granting partial restrictions to seven others, highlighting the relationship between Western commitments and strategic expectations made in respect of national interests.⁸⁵

⁸³ Weber, Michael A. "Child Soldiers Prevention Act: Security Assistance Restrictions." Congressional Research Service. October 11, 2023.<https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/IF10901>

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*

⁸⁵ Stimson Center. "Taking Stock of Biden's Delayed — but Encouraging — Progress on Child Soldiers Prevention." February 20, 2024.<https://www.stimson.org/2023/taking-stock-of-bidens-delayed-but-encouraging-progress-on-child-soldiers-prevention/>

On the contrary, France has taken an operational role as the United Nations Security Council penholder on conflicts regarding the Central African Republic and the Democratic Republic of Congo, regularly advocating for the implementation of child protection provisions within UN peacekeeping mandates.⁸⁶

The Western Bloc broadly supports the Vancouver Principles of 2017, which call on troop and police contributing countries to UN peacekeeping operations to strengthen child protection training and safeguards into their deployment.⁸⁷ This reflects the bloc's preference for promoting child protection within current security measures rather than creating new standalone enforcement bodies. Western countries have also Security Council briefings to spotlight specific crises, with the United States flagging recruitment by both warring parties in Sudan's conflict, where young boys have been recruited as child soldiers, alongside cases of child abduction, detention, and torture documented in Ukraine.⁸⁸ The Western bloc generally uses strong normative language, sanctions-linked accountability for reported parties, and well-resourced reintegration programming.

Latin American Bloc

In Latin America, Colombia has been singled out as the country most affected by the issue at hand. Colombia has been experiencing a lot of internal conflict, and even though a peace agreement was signed in 2016 between the government and the nation's most important guerrilla group, child soldier recruitment has increased by 300% over the past five years, according to data from the year 2024, which was verified by the UN. This problem is especially pressing across poor rural areas in the country where children do not have a lot of educational opportunities or access to jobs⁸⁹. Colombia has tried to solve it primarily by implementing a DDR and child recruitment prevention model mainly

⁸⁶ Watchlist on Children and Armed Conflict. "Children and Armed Conflict Monthly Update — June 2026." June 2026. <https://watchlist.org/publications/children-and-armed-conflict-monthly-update-june-2026/>

⁸⁷ Government of Canada. "Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers." November 15, 2017. https://www.international.gc.ca/world-monde/issues_development-e-njeux_developpement/human_rights-droits_homme/principes-vancouver-principes.aspx?lang=eng

⁸⁸ United Nations Security Council. "Facing Record-High Violations in 2023, Security Council Explores Ways to Bolster Norms to Protect Children in Armed Conflict." SC/15745. June 2024. <https://press.un.org/en/2024/sc15745.doc.htm>

⁸⁹ Colarullo Giacomo. *Child recruitment and use by armed groups in Colombia quadruples over five years*. UNICEF. 2026. <https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/child-recruitment-and-use-armed-groups-in-colombia-quadruples-over-five-years>

centered around rehabilitating victims and expanding socio-economic opportunities for them to be less vulnerable to re-recruitment⁹⁰.

Africa and the Middle East Bloc

As touched upon in previous sections in this study guide, the West and Central Africa region stands among those most affected by human rights violations against children in war contexts. According to UNICEF, from the year 2016, more than 21,000 children have been confirmed by the UN as having been recruited and used by armed forces in West and Central Africa⁹¹. Within the broader African and Middle East region, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Somalia, Sudan, South Sudan, Nigeria, the Central African Republic, Syria, Yemen, Iraq, Israel and Palestine have all suffered from the problem of child soldiers in one way or the other.

As a result, it would make the most sense for many of the countries making up the African and Middle Eastern Bloc to act as strong advocates for action on the matter. They would mainly pay attention to stopping recruitment, guaranteeing rehabilitation, and securing international assistance, always bearing in mind the importance of safeguarding state sovereignty. On top of this, they would most likely acknowledge the root causes of child soldier use and recruitment and attempt to address them. A lot of these countries have undergone prolonged conflicts and have had to endure the presence of various non-state armed groups operating completely outside the government and international law. If this was not enough, there is also a lot of poverty in some of the regions affected by the child soldier problem, and this means that a lot of the children living here are particularly vulnerable to recruitment.

Asian Bloc

In Asia, countries such as Myanmar, the Philippines, or Afghanistan have experienced cases of child soldier use and recruitment. At the Asia-Pacific Conference on the Use of Children as Soldiers held in the year 2000 in Nepal, which culminated in the Kathmandu Declaration on the Use of Children as Soldiers, it was recognised that Asia is the second

⁹⁰ International Organization for Migration. Colombia: DDR and Child Soldier Issues: A Monthly Review. Reliefweb. 2018. <https://reliefweb.int/report/colombia/colombia-ddr-and-child-soldier-issues-monthly-review-february-2018>

⁹¹ Bisin Sandra. The West and Central Africa region among the most affected by grave violations against children in armed conflict. UNICEF. 2021. <https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/west-and-central-africa-region-among-most-affected-grave-violations-against-children>

region most impacted by child soldier recruitment after Africa and that it is expected that approximately 75,000 children are involved in armed conflicts in some way or the other across countries such as the ones that were previously mentioned⁹². Hence, similarly to Africa and the Middle East, the Asian countries should actively call for the implementation of more effective solutions to the issue of child soldiers.

International Organizations

Within the UN, UNICEF stands out as one of the most active agencies seeking to address the problem of child soldier use and recruitment. As mentioned in previous sections, it has been involved in negotiating child soldier releases as well as in providing psychological support to former child soldiers in an attempt to reintegrate them back into society. Simultaneously, the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict tries to encourage governments and armed groups to stop using and recruiting minors and is also in charge of monitoring violations against children's rights in contexts of war⁹³.

At the regional level, the European Union has played an active role in protecting the rights of former child soldiers by funding various education and reintegration programs in countries like Uganda, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Colombia, Syria, and Sudan⁹⁴. More concretely, the EU has supported child soldiers in the Central African Republic through the provision of temporary care and reintegration kits as well as vocational training⁹⁵. Another EU initiative which has also demonstrated a strong commitment towards the rehabilitation of child soldiers is the decision to fund a project organised by UNICEF aiming to fully reintegrate children formerly associated with armed groups in South Sudan⁹⁶. Similarly, the African Union stands out as a key fighter against child soldier use and recruitment alongside the EU since it has led missions such as the African Union Transition Mission in Somalia (ATMIS), focused on training 30 military officers on how to

⁹² Pillai R. V. Asia-Pacific Conference on the Use of Children as Soldiers. Nepal. 2000. <file:///C:/Users/Usuario/Downloads/Asia%20Pacific%20Conference%20on%20the%20use%20of%20Children%20as%20Soldiers.pdf>

⁹³ Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict. *Children Have Rights. Children Want Peace. Prove It Matters*. <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en>

⁹⁴ European Union External Action. *War is no Place for Children*. 2020. https://www.eeas.europa.eu/eeas/war-no-place-children_en

⁹⁵ European Union External Action. *Child Soldiers: Children need Protection, not Trauma*. 2023. https://www.eeas.europa.eu/eeas/child-soldiers-children-need-protection-not-trauma_en

⁹⁶ Directorate-General for International Partnerships. *Ex-post evaluation provision of reintegration services for children formerly associated with armed forces and groups in South Sudan*. European Commission. 2023. https://international-partnerships.ec.europa.eu/publications-library/ex-post-evaluation-provision-reintegration-services-children-formerly-associated-armed-forces-and_en

protect children in war contexts and on implementing measures aimed at reducing the chances of children being recruited or abused during armed conflicts⁹⁷. Finally, while organizations such as ASEAN, the OAE, or the Arab League have been less active on the matter, they have also positioned themselves against it.

NGOs and Civil Society

Some of the most active NGOs focused on tackling the issue of child soldier use and recruitment are Save the Children, War Child, Child Soldiers International, Human Rights Watch, and the International Committee of the Red Cross⁹⁸.

Save the Children, for instance, has been helping former child soldiers in countries such as the Democratic Republic of Congo through economic and psychological assistance⁹⁹. Save the Children has been particularly important in leading advocacy efforts through initiatives such as the Stop the War on Children Report, which documents the atrocities suffered by children in war zones, emphasising how child soldier recruitment is a grave violation of children's rights¹⁰⁰. In a similar manner, Child Soldiers International and Human Rights Watch have also stood out for publishing global reports documenting child soldier use and recruitment rates¹⁰¹. Child Soldiers International, in particular, has been an active proponent of raising the global recruitment age to 18. Finally, Watchlist on Children and Armed Conflict is a less famous NGO but is also highly relevant since it has long focused on addressing the problem of child soldiers by assisting the UN Security Council Working Group on Children and Armed Conflict through research and recommendations¹⁰².

⁹⁷ ATMIS. *ATMIS Troops Trained on Child Protection in Armed Conflict*. 2024. <https://atmis-au.org/atmis-troops-trained-on-child-protection-in-armed-conflict/>

⁹⁸ Elder Shannon. *Top Organizations Helping Child Soldiers Recover*. The Borgen Project. 2017. <https://borgenproject.org/organizations-helping-child-soldiers-recover/>

⁹⁹ Garmirian Claire. *Children Recruited into Armed Groups in DR Congo Describe Abduction, Drugging, and Violence as Call for Greater Action*. Save the Children. Kinshasa. 2026. <https://www.savethechildren.org/us/about-us/media-and-news/2026-press-releases/drc-children-recruited-into-armed-groups>

¹⁰⁰ Save the Children. *Child Soldiers: The Tragic End of Childhood for Boys and Girls in Conflict*. 2026. <https://www.savethechildren.org/us/charity-stories/child-soldiers>

¹⁰¹ Human Rights Watch. *Child Soldiers Worldwide*. 2012. <https://www.hrw.org/news/2012/03/12/child-soldiers-worldwide>

¹⁰² Watchlist on Children and Armed Conflict. *About*. 2026. <https://watchlist.org/about/advocate/>

07

Questions a Resolution Must Answer

The following questions address the range of subtopics that should be taken into consideration during the debate and resolution-writing processes:

- 1 How can the international community better address the root causes of child soldier recruitment? These usually include but are not limited to poverty, instability, and limited educational and professional opportunities.
- 2 What new mechanisms could be put in place in order to support the immediate identification and disarmament of child soldiers and how can chances of re-recruitment be mitigated?
- 3 How can educational, professional, and recreational opportunities be improved in order to prevent the voluntary enrollment into armed groups by children as well as to guarantee the economic and social reintegration of former child soldiers?
- 4 How can reintegration programs better deal with the separate physical and psychological needs of boy and girl child soldiers?
- 5 How can emerging technologies be ethically and successfully relied on in order to identify, track, and protect formerly recruited child soldiers?
- 6 How can the international community make sure that non-state armed groups who typically use and recruit children to partake in armed conflicts are effectively held accountable under international law?
- 7 How can the international community ensure that current frameworks remain effective and applied in practice?

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